

Active Directory Home Lab

Forgot Password

Platform: Oracle VirtualBox | OS: Windows Server 2022 + Windows 11

Troubleshooting: WINDOWS11\Administrator Account Recovery

Problem

Lost access to the Windows 11\Administrator local account due to a forgotten password. The account existed on the machine but could not be accessed directly.

Why The Account Was Disabled

The built-in local Administrator account on Windows 11 is disabled by default on every fresh install — Microsoft does this automatically as a security measure. It was never manually disabled; it just never got enabled in the first place. Since the machine was joined to the domain pretty early on, domain accounts like LAB\Administrator and local domain user account were used to log in instead, so the local Administrator account just sat there in the background the whole time without ever being touched. It only became an issue when trying to access it directly for the first time.

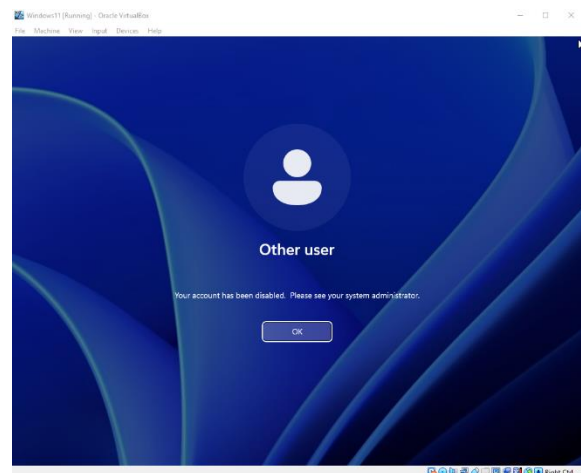
What Was Tried First

Checked the Windows Server through Active Directory Users and Computers to see if the local Windows 11 account could be reset from there. Turns out local machine accounts aren't managed through Active Directory at all — only domain accounts are. So nothing related to Windows 11\Administrator showed up there.

How It Was Fixed

1. Logged into the Windows 11 machine using a domain user account (Ben Campbell) since those credentials were still accessible
2. Opened Command Prompt and ran it as administrator — used **LAB\Administrator** credentials to elevate the privileges since the local admin was inaccessible
3. Ran the following command to set a new password:

```
net user Administrator  
YourNewPassword123
```

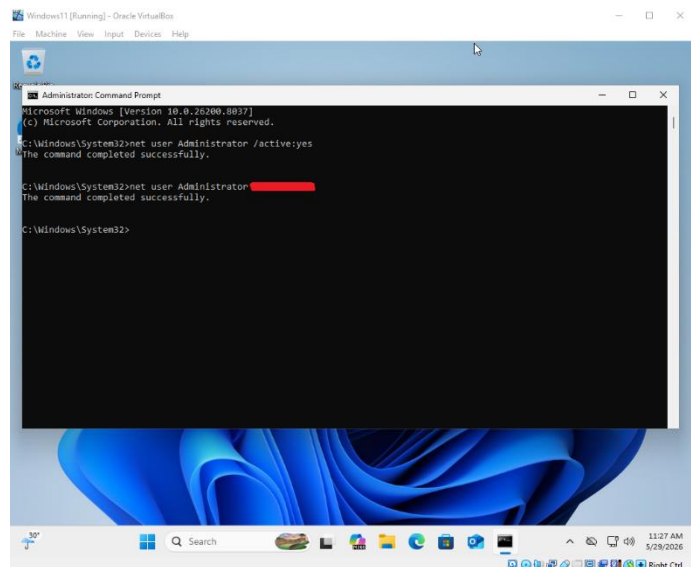


4. Tried logging in as WINDOWS11\Administrator but hit an **Account is Disabled** error

5. Went back into Ben Campbell's account, opened CMD as admin the same way, and ran:

net user Administrator /active: yes

6. Reset the password one more time and successfully logged in as WINDOWS11\Administrator



Key Takeaways

- The local Windows 11 Administrator account is disabled by default on every fresh install — it has to be manually enabled when needed
- Local machine accounts and domain accounts are completely separate — local accounts won't show up in Active Directory
- As long as you have domain admin credentials, you can elevate CMD privileges on any domain-joined machine to manage local accounts
- Keep track of both local and domain credentials separately — they serve different purposes

